

## Inhabiting Contradiction

In 'Wretched of the Earth', Frantz Fanon argues that colonialism extends beyond political domination to reorganise the psychological, cultural, and spatial realities of those it governs. 'Colonialism is not satisfied with snaring the people in its net or of draining the colonized brain of any form or substance. With a kind of perverted logic, it turns its attention to the past of the colonized people and distorts it, disfigures it, and destroys it' (Fanon 170). The progression from "distorts" to "disfigures" to "destroys" suggests an escalating violence directed at the conditions of heritage through which identity is formed. By targeting the past, colonialism disrupts the temporal continuity that allows identity to feel rooted in place and history, severing it from any stable origin. Identity, then, is no longer a natural expression of self or environment, but something produced through imposed and often contradictory systems of meaning. This disruption can be further understood through Richard van Leeuwen's claim that, 'home is not self-evidently synonymous with the place where someone is born... it requires a story as well, a narrative that explains one's presence in that place, one's relationship to it, one's position there, and the meaning of one's presence in that place'. (Leeuwen 1) If home depends on narrative coherence—on the ability to explain one's relationship to place—then Fanon's description of the destruction of the past becomes a destruction of the very narrative framework that makes such coherence possible. Crucially, this narrative dispossession is not confined to the colonized alone. As I will argue, the instability and irony it produces extends to implicate the colonizer as well—identity on both sides of the colonial encounter emerges not as natural or self-sufficient, but as constructed, relational, and fundamentally contingent.

While Orientalism can be understood as a “Western style for dominating, restructuring, and having authority over the Orient” (Said 3), Edward Said emphasizes that its significance lies not only in how the East is represented, but in what those representations produce for the West itself. As he argues, “Orientalism is more particularly valuable as a sign of European Atlantic power over the Orient than it is as a veridic discourse about the Orient” (Said 6). The distinction between “power” and “veridic discourse” reveals that Orientalism is less about accurately describing the Orient and more about asserting control through knowledge production. In this sense, the Orient functions as a constructed counterpart—irrational, backward, and exotic—against which the West defines itself as rational, modern, and authoritative. The positioning of the West as the producer of knowledge about the “Other” thus stabilizes its own identity, but only through a process that is fundamentally relational and dependent. As a result, Western identity is not self-contained or inherent, but constructed through the same narrative impositions that structure colonial domination.

The reversal of narrative in *Season of Migration to the North* highlights the complexity of individual and national identity even post-independence, while also demonstrating how both colonized and colonizer are caught within constructed, unstable narratives of selfhood—neither able to return to a stable origin. They are both defined through the terms of the encounter between them. During Mustafa Sa’eed’s trial, after he has weaponized Orientalist expectations, he becomes subjected to them in his own defense: “This Mustafa Sa’eed does not exist. He’s an illusion, a lie... These girls were not killed by Mustafa Sa’eed but by the germ of a deadly disease that assailed them a thousand years ago” (Salih 32). He is reframed not as an individual agent and stripped of personal accountability and reconstituted as an abstract figure—an embodiment of a pathological “East” positioned against a rational “West.” The courtroom

becomes a microcosm of Orientalism that insists on interpreting him through pre-existing frameworks. Mustafa is not being judged as a man, but narrated as a function of a broader ideological struggle. His identity is thus rendered doubly unstable: first through his own strategic performances, and then through the West's insistence on fixing him within a mythologized and pathological narrative. The irony, however, is that this process reveals the fragility of Western identity itself. To explain Mustafa, the court must construct an entire civilizational opposition, transforming a criminal trial into what Mustafa recognizes as "a conflict between two worlds" (Salih 32). Referring to him as "a noble person whose mind was able to absorb Western civilization but it broke his heart" (Salih 32) not only describes Mustafa but also reinforces British imperial identity as a superior civilising authority. Western civilization is positioned as the standard against which value is measured—something to be absorbed, mastered, and survived—thereby naturalizing its dominance while framing non-Western subjects as defined by their relationship to it. In this sense, the language of the trial works less to explain Mustafa than to stabilize the West's image of itself as rational, authoritative, and culturally preeminent. Yet what the trial also exposes, in van Leeuwen's terms, is the West's own dependence on narrative: it cannot simply assert its identity, it must continuously tell a story about itself through the figure of the Other—and it is in the telling of that story that its contingency becomes visible.

Yet this claim to superiority is also undercut by its own dependence. Later in *Season of Migration to the North*, an Englishman, defending imperial influence, asserts that "you cannot manage to live without us. You used to complain about colonialism and when we left, you created the legend of neo-colonialism... our presence, in an open or undercover form, is as indispensable to you as air and water" (Salih 49). While intended to reaffirm British authority, the statement inadvertently reveals the extent to which that authoritarian identity relies on its

portrayal of the colonized identity. Because even though the colonized may have created neo-colonialism, the West never truly left and continued to ‘direct [our] affairs from afar’ (Salih 45). Imperial power was never truly concluded but was instead structurally and necessarily reconfigured. What is framed as dependency on the part of the colonized instead reveals a deeper dependency within British imperial identity itself, as its sense of superiority must be continuously produced through intervention and the maintenance of influence. Western imperial identity thus emerges not as self-sufficient, but as contingent—sustained through the ongoing construction of an “Other” that both produces and stabilizes its claim to authority.

On questions of national identity post-independence, the narrator reflects that “Sooner or later they will leave our country... Once again we shall be as we were—ordinary people—and if we are lies we shall be lies of our own making” (Salih 42). I argue that this statement is not only relevant to the formerly colonized, but extends to the West as well. While Sudan must confront its inability to return to a pre-colonial “truth” and instead negotiate identities shaped by colonial histories, British imperial identity was itself already a constructed narrative. The condition of being “lies of our own making” is not a stage unique to post-independence nations, but a shared consequence of imperial history. Both colonized and colonizer are left to construct identities in the absence of stable foundations.

Literary works like *Season of Migration* give us an understanding of Oriental and Western identity contradictions, but we see more of its depth in non fiction works like *The Idea of Englishness: English Culture, National Identity and Social Thought*. Krishan Kumar notes that, “English identity only really emerged with the end of empire in the 1960s. Up to that time empire had, for the English at least, been a kind of substitute for national identity” (Kumar 12). The emphasis on “for the English” is significant, as it highlights that what appeared to be a stable

national identity was in fact sustained through imperial expansion rather than internal coherence. With the collapse of empire, this “protective layer” was removed, leaving English identity exposed as contingent rather than inherent. This is not simply a historical observation but a confirmation of what Edward Said's framework implies: when the apparatus through which Western identity was produced—the ongoing narration of the Orient as its inferior counterpart—began to dissolve, so too did the coherence of the identity it had been sustaining. This emphasis is also particularly important when looking at the other nations within the British Isles. ‘For the Scots, Welsh and Irish, the cultivation of their distinct identities was a means of offsetting the dominance of the English – the old enemy – in both the Empire and the United Kingdom. The Empire afforded them an opportunity to do so on a scale and in a manner impossible within the home country itself. Scots, Welsh and Irish were able to carve out distinct “niches” for themselves within the Empire. (Kumar 151)’ Unlike English identity, which was diffused through imperial projection, these identities were sharpened through their position in relation to dominance. There is an irony here: subordination, paradoxically, produced a more stable ground for identity formation than dominance did. While the colonizing center relied on external expansion to sustain a sense of self, those positioned in relation to that center—whether within or beyond the empire—were able to articulate more defined and localized identities. The result is a reversal of expectation: the imperial core, rather than being the most stable site of identity, emerges as the most dependent and internally unresolved.

The relational construction of identity becomes even more complex when considering that the distinction between "Orient" and "Occident" is not as externally bounded as it appears. The Orient was typically positioned as existing outside the West, yet the logics of Orientalism and what has been termed Occidentalism operate along the same continuum, rather than as opposites.

As Simon Gikandi noted, "Englishness was itself a product of the colonial culture that it seemed to have created elsewhere" (Gikandi). This is a significant reversal as it shows that empire did not express a pre-existing English self—it constituted one. What is even more revealing, however, is that this constitutive process was not only directed outward toward colonized territories like Sudan, but inward as well. "Domestic Occidentalism was the necessary correlate of an eventually overseas- directed Orientalism: they were two sides of the same coin" (Makdisi 10). The urban poor of London were described in the same racial and civilizational terms as colonized peoples abroad, and the "City Arabs" of St. Giles's were Orientalized within the metropole itself. English identity, in other words, was produced through an internal purging process: "in order to enable it to be distinguished more clearly from an Orient over which it claimed the right to rule, the Occident had to be cleansed of its own inner Orient" (Makdisi 17). The boundary between Occident and Orient was never a clean geographical line—it was an unstable frontier that ran through England itself. This furthers my argument that imperial identity was not only projected outward but also actively produced within the metropole. Rather than existing as a coherent identity prior to empire, it emerges through the same relational and contingent process that structures colonial identity itself—confirming its' self-certainty was always dependent on a colonial encounter it claimed to govern.

This is evident in the tension between Britishness and Englishness: while British identity is historically tied to empire and expansion, unlike the Scottish, Irish and Welsh national identities, Englishness itself often lacks a stable, clearly defined national narrative outside of that imperial framework. Rather than existing as a coherent identity, it emerges through contrast—against both colonized "others" abroad and internal differences within Britain. English identity was hollow not because it lacked meaning, but because its meaning was never internally secured. The

distinction between “home” and “empire” is far less stable than it appears. If, as Orientalism demonstrates, Western identity depends on the production of an external Other, then that opposition must be continuously maintained—and, crucially, cannot remain purely external. In conclusion, what appears as a system for managing external difference ultimately produces an intensified preoccupation with internal identity formation. The boundary the West sought to draw between itself and its Others was never securely external, but ran through the metropole itself. Fanon's account of colonialism destroying the past of the colonized finds its precise parallel in the colonizer's own condition: English national identity cannot return to an original self, as it was never internally secured. Western identity depends on the production of an external Other, yet that opposition cannot remain purely external and must be continuously reproduced within. Englishness, then, does not precede empire but emerges through it, and its crises of identity did not end with empire — it continues to be reproduced through new episodes of boundary-drawing, new attempts to locate the self through the construction of an Other. What remains is not a stable national identity, but a condition of ongoing contradiction where identity is continually produced through narratives that both sustain and unsettle it.

## **References**

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